

KF50 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

KF Confession 12 is the heartbeat of our redeemed life in Christ:

We circulate our true resources, reconnecting to our Creator and to the Creation.

We are approaching the end of the Karis Fellowships training cycle. You might like to review the meditation and mindfulness methods that we have practiced and choose one that works for you. Pursue your meditation practice diligently. You will gain the greatest benefits if you practice for at least twenty minutes in the morning and twenty minutes later in the day. You may wish to practice the same method for one year, or you may wish to practice the method offered in the lesson. It's your meditation practice. Do whatever works for you.

This month we will practice a meditation called **Waiting on the Lord**. This meditation blends easily with other meditation practices, or it can stand alone. In this lesson we will briefly prepare using **Alternate Nostril Breathing** and the **Sunlight Meditation**.

Take a meditation posture. Straighten your neck and lower your chin a little. Imagine that your spine is like a radio tower, with the pole of your head reaching toward the heavens and your tailbone reaching toward the earth. Gently close your eyes and begin with two minutes of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. *(Pause for 2 minutes)*

Pause, and allow your shoulders to drop back into a relaxed position. Scan and observe your body. Do you notice any tightness or pain? Breathe, and with the exhale release tension in your body. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, with eyelids gently closed, lift your eyes and imagine the sun or a lamp shining onto your forehead. Breathe. Imagine that you are looking through your forehead into the light and that the light is pouring into your face as you breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

At some point, perhaps later if not right now, you might imagine that you are gazing into the face of Jesus

or into the glory of God. For one minute, just breathe and gaze while you wait before the Lord. (*Pause for 1 minute*)

Pause, and gently open your eyes. Take a deep breath and return to the meeting.

Our hymn for this meditation is *Be Thou My Vision*.

Be Thou my Wisdom and Thou my true Word,
I ever with Thee and Thou with me, Lord;
Thou my great Father, I Thy true son;
Thou in me dwelling, and I with Thee one.¹

When you practice this meditation, you might also consider Isaiah 40:31.

But those who wait on the Lord shall renew their strength;
They shall mount up with wings like eagles;
They shall run and not be weary;
They shall walk and not faint.

God promises these great benefits to those who learn to wait on Him.

Take a deep breath.

(*If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?"*)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Let's listen again to our final KF Confession of purpose and mission:

We circulate our true resources, reconnecting to our Creator and to the Creation.

Last month, we talked about taking responsibility for the damage we have done. Now, we can learn to co-labor with God to redeem our debts and give back what we have stolen. We can also give karis gifts that help repair damage we did not cause. By circulating gifts, we help God heal not only ourselves but also this world.

What does it mean to circulate gifts? The gifts that we give come out of the storehouse of our true resources. God designed each of us to have our own supply of resources, but in our misorientation we refuse to access and develop them. Through our efforts toward orientation, we discover that we have much more to give than we realized. The Idol cannot be generous with its resources. It is not self-sustaining, nor is it connected to the Creation, so it must crave and snatch to support itself.

In the wilderness, Satan tempted Jesus to take control of His life and regain His comfort by defaulting to the misoriented solutions of resignation, mastery, and self-effacement. Jesus was first tempted to use the simple expedient of magic to turn stones into bread. Satan then promised Him control over the kingdoms of the world in return for worship. Finally, he encouraged Jesus to jump off the temple as a way of forcing God to intervene in His circumstances.²

The resigned type might be represented as the Free Loafer, the mastery type as the Kingdom Builder, and the self-effacing type as the Temple Jumper. Free Loafers want life to be easy. They prefer to remain detached, and they resist circulation in an effort to maintain their sense of self-sufficiency. Kingdom Builders can be generous, but they exact servitude and admiration. Temple jumpers often throw themselves into intolerable situations that require others, including God, to rescue them. They are overly generous with their resources and hope that others will see their need and restore what they have given away. Their unwillingness to take care of themselves forces the community to support them.

For decades people have written about and preached a gospel of attracting and actualizing a certain reality by positive thinking. This gospel teaches that if you truly believe that something will come to you—if you fully imagine, feel, and trust that it will come—then it will come. Some people even claim that the Bible supports this idea. They believe that if you have enough “faith”, you can magically make God do for you whatever you imagine or want. This gospel has caused a great deal of discouragement and anxiety in the church because it isn’t true. The Bible teaches that we keep the flow of provision circulating by putting our trust in God, orienting our lives, and making trustworthy choices.

Oriented Christians understand that they are creatures living in a material and spiritual ecosystem, and they therefore recognize that in order to pursue their high calling in Christ they must circulate their resources. The True Self flows in harmony and correspondence with the Creation, giving and receiving as naturally as we breathe and as the tide flows. When we are oriented, we let go in order to receive, and in this way we nourish and circulate our own life force. Just as our heart pumps blood through bodies, so we pump the energetic flow of the Creation; as a result, we thrive. We are the heart that keeps the Creation circulating, so the moment that we hoard or grab, the heart of the Creation stops beating. In KF, we are learning to pump efficiently and with joy.

This circulation of karis is an ongoing cycle of realistic and responsible letting go and receiving. The heart of our soul receives and pumps karis just as our physical heart receives and pumps blood. You might ask, “What are we actually receiving and pumping?” That’s rather hard to describe, but you can think of it like this: karis flow is a kind of movement of life force or energy. Our actions in the seen world effect changes in the unseen world. The unseen world receives the flow of energy, translates it into its own force, and then sends the energy back to the seen world in forms that surprise us. When we live in this flow, we let go of any preconceived ideas or judgments about what *should* return to us from the unseen, and we respond in an oriented way to what returns to us. We mindfully observe, we are grateful, and we trust that all things are here for our training. Once we decide that training is of supreme value, everything becomes an opportunity to train that prepares us for the delights and responsibilities of the high calling of our inheritance in Christ. Our karis response to this training creates more circulation.

Particularly at the beginning of your work, you might feel that you are making a lot of effort but only gaining small benefits. In past lessons we talked about damage in terms of debt. If your immediate outcomes seem like a poor return on the hard work that you are investing, you are simply experiencing evidence that you are still deep in debt. The deeper you are in debt, the longer it will take to produce discernible, oriented results. This process is very much like turning a flywheel or priming a pump. You must use extra muscle to get the machine going, but once the mechanism is working, you can rely on its design to draw power from other sources. Building the foundation of a building or a business requires much more effort than adding the finishing touches. In KF we are laying new foundations for our lives. It takes time and a great deal of effort just to begin the process of orienting your life, and it takes even more time and effort, as well as developed CORE muscles, to effect beneficial changes in the material world. As

you continue to be courageous and oriented, live in reality, and practice endurance, you will see increasing evidence of powerful and positive change in your life.

Whenever we try to use our newly acquired skills and benefits to actualize the unfulfilled dreams of our idealized glory, energetic circulation stagnates. If, however, we focus on the next step in the dance of life, forgetting all that we have formerly relied upon to support our pride, we are carried along in the harmonious and oriented flow of Creation. With our hearts set on winning the race, we press forward to discover our potential in Christ.³ Our True Self grows stronger when we circulate today, and it atrophies when we are satisfied with our stories of yesterday's generosity, miracles, or judgments. Our natural habitat is a place of circulation where we receive and let go, today, in the flow.⁴

The flow of karis circulation is exactly like dancing with a partner. If you have ever tried to learn the waltz, you know that the first steps can feel awkward. When the music starts flowing, you can barely keep up. You courageously endure the shame of stepping on someone else's toes and the pain of presenting your own toes to be stepped on. Then, after a great deal of practice, you suddenly catch the music and are able to dance. You feel exquisite joy over your brief accomplishment and are momentarily distracted by euphoria. You might even stop dancing so that you can take some pride in your accomplishment, but in doing so, you disconnect from the present moment. The music flows on, but you have stopped dancing. You have allowed prideful attachment to your achievements or fear of failure to interfere with the next step. You cannot cling to old things and, at the same time, flow into new opportunities. Your goal is to enjoy the present moment of harmony and then allow it to disappear into the joy of the next moment of harmony. With practice, your whole life becomes a series of joyful dance steps that follow the music of the flow. As you allow one step to pass, you turn your attention to the next step and experience the unique harmony that it brings.⁵ There is no hoarding or clinging; if you want to stay in the dance, you have to let go. You have to let go of former glory, and you also have to forgive yourself for not making the grade. If, however, you are struggling to let go of the pride of past achievements and the self-hate of former failures, be compassionate toward yourself. It takes time and effort to learn new skills and to train your CORE muscles so that you can dance.

Whenever you use energy to nurse resentment and maintain grudges, you are hoarding energy that is intended to flow. Forgiveness releases misoriented energy and circulates a gift. Jesus told us to bless our enemies rather than resenting them because He wants us to gain the benefits of circulation. When you forgive, you allow misoriented energy to go back to whoever is responsible for it. You are then free to joyfully embrace your next step.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Great Teacher of the flow, I want to learn how to dance. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 12 is the law of Christ's kingdom and our path to real glory:

We circulate our true resources, reconnecting to our Creator and to the Creation.

Let's look at my translation of **Luke 6:31–38**. In this passage, Jesus is teaching His followers the principle of karis circulation.

³¹And just as you want people to do to you, do the same to them. ³²If you show agape love to those who love you, what karis is that to you? Look at it this way: even misoriented people love those who love them. ³³And if you do good to those who do good to you, what karis is it to you? Even misoriented people do that. ³⁴And if you lend to those from whom you hope or expect to receive, what karis is it to you? Even the misoriented lend to the misoriented in order to receive the same things in return. ³⁵Instead, love your enemies and do good and lend, expecting nothing from them in return. Then your reward will be abundant, and you will be revealed as the sons of the Most High, your Father, because He does active good and is kind to those who are hurtful and against karis. ³⁶Become merciful, just as your Father is merciful and has pity. ³⁷Do not judge, and you will in no way be judged. Also, do not condemn, and you will not be condemned. Release, and you will be released. ³⁸Give, and others will give into your open arms a true measure, already pressed down, already shaken and running over. This is how it works: in whatever proportion you measure out your resources, the same proportion will be measured back to you.

Take a deep breath.

Jesus begins His teaching about karis by reminding His disciples of what is often called the Golden Rule: "Do for others what you want them to do for you."⁶ Give in proportion to your MATH—your money, abilities, time, and health. Learn to open your arms, and then watch for the response from others, from the Creation, and from God. Learn to trust. In other words, begin karis circulation with a gift. As sons and heirs of the Most High God, we are the patrons who initiate our relationships by giving a gift. We do something. If we are simply reciprocating by returning a gift to others, we are not the benefactor giving out of karis.

Karis is more than being kind to those who have already shown kindness to you. Karis requires the ingredient of trust. If you show kindness to those who have shown kindness to you, you do not have to trust them to return a benefit; you have already received a benefit. Similarly, if you lend or give to another person with the expectation of a particular return, you are not in a trusting karis relationship; you are in a contract based on the law of mutual expectations. Contracts are necessary in the market economy, and people set them up because they don't trust each other. A contract is intended to bind another person and exact a premeditated return. You can rarely feel gratitude in relationships that are based on contracts, because the return simply fulfills your expectation. If you do something for someone else and then feel disappointed with their response, you know that you have an expectation. You are not in karis; you are in a contract.

Non-karis relationships are based on greed and fear, and greed and fear often translate into control and expectations; in other words, there are strings attached. Misoriented people give what is easiest for them to give, and they are usually unaware that their generous motives are serving their search for neurotic glory. Their relationships are like those in a soap opera. Think about TV shows, books, and movies for a moment. How much of the drama is based on people's judgments and claims about what is fair and right? Even the news media, which purports to bring us the truth about events, knows how drama, judgment,

and conflict attract an audience. Newsfeeds are designed to create anxiety and to incite people to judge an event as unfair and take sides. Anxiety and the love of drama generate a compulsive desire to know more, and this compulsive desire is exploited by the media to lure the audience back into the market economy.

In our lives, as in drama, conflict usually centers around the failure of one person or group to meet the expectations of another. A fleeting sense of harmony can only be experienced if everyone feels that their expectations and claims are being met. This kind of harmony is very vulnerable, however, because egocentric needs cannot be suppressed forever, and people will eventually start making demands. Misoriented people exaggerate the value of their own contributions while undervaluing the contributions of others. Some are not satisfied until they have it all. Others are not satisfied until they have nothing and are free from responsibilities.

Karis relationships are built on trust and mutual generosity. God invites you into karis relationship by giving you a great gift—the restoration of your soul—and by returning a gift, you invite God into more relationship. If you want a karis relationship with anyone, you have to respond with gifts that are proportionate to your MATH and to your gratitude. Your response is a gift that says, “I value my relationship with you, not the return I expect from you.” When you see how others respond, you learn a lot about the quality of your relationships, and you find out how much others value you.

Whenever you give out of karis, you go into the not-knowing. You can always trust that there will be a response to your gift, but you cannot know what that response will be, and in karis you do not attach to an expectation of what it should be. When gifts are returned, you become so rich within your True Self and in your relationship with God and others that you would rather bless your enemies than hold grudges against them.⁷ Forgiveness and letting go become natural and easy in the rich flow of circulation. Holding a grudge is like refusing to dance because someone has stepped on your toe. Oriented people would rather dance.

Jesus wants us to bless our enemies and do good to them by offering a noble gift that invites exploration and discovery. He teaches us to allow karis energy to flow toward our enemies rather than blocking energy through our judgments and indictments of injury. Your unconditional gift offers others the freedom to show you who they really are. You may find out that someone you thought was your enemy actually wants to be your friend. You might also discover that an enemy wants to remain an enemy. Your gift reveals who you are, and it also reveals the character of the one who receives it. That is valuable knowledge. A contract destroys the surprising potential of what God and others might do through karis. Contracts narrow the result to one outcome. Karis opens the door to all kinds of possibilities.

In karis circulation, you give to discover what is possible. Your gift is an exploration of trust or faith. You give without expecting or insisting that you deserve a particular return. You simply trust that something will return to you either from God or from others and the Creation. Through offering your gifts, you simply pump energy out, but what is returned to you cannot be predicted and may have no direct connection with what you have circulated. However, as you keep pumping without attaching to a particular outcome, you will most certainly experience a world of increasing abundance and circulating flow.

Oriented people look forward to what returns to them in karis circulation. They confidently anticipate that God and others will respond with invitations to build relationships of deeper trust, leading to greater opportunities. Can you see how increased trust brings more freedom, not only to you but also to the whole community? Poised for the next joyful step, oriented people continue to A-S-A-P—Ask, Simplify,

Adventure, Prioritize. Every gift they give is an adventure and an exploration of gratitude. They throw their gift into the flow and then watch to see what happens.

Jesus is showing you in this passage that you are too rich to live like those who demand that others reciprocate in a certain way. It is only when we give without attaching to a particular imagined response that we can recognize who is trustworthy and who is in our karis community. Misoriented people can only go as far as exchanging mutual expectations, which disable their gratitude and make them blind to the karis gifts that others offer. Their demands are based on law and contract, not on karis. Contracts and law are based on distrust; the purpose of karis, however, is to build trust. All of us are afraid to trust, and that makes karis a lot scarier and more challenging, but only karis can reveal the glory and goodness of God and the real glory of you. In karis, we give because of who we are—the sons of the Most High, who have an inheritance in this world and in the next. We give to see what will happen, knowing that all of our giving is ultimately a gift to God in karis response to all that God has given to us.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord Jesus, teach me to let go and get in the flow. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take a few notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider letting go of something, perhaps a grudge or a gift. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you consider *letting go of something, perhaps a grudge or a gift*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold in your awareness whatever you may be experiencing when you *consider letting go*. You might notice a compulsion to justify or to simply dismiss thoughts and feelings. Try to hold your experience up to the light and mindfully observe whatever you may be experiencing. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing as you *consider letting go of something, perhaps a grudge or a gift*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what greed, offended pride, fear, or release feels like in your body. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider letting go of something*. Does that feel comfortable or uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Does the thought of letting go of this thing feel good or bad? *(Pause)* What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* What do you fear or hope for? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore what you might let go.
- Welcome the gentle Holy Breath of truth, who wants to teach you how to circulate.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁸

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I learn to circulate, I let go of the craving to hoard and control.
- As I learn to circulate, I let go of the craving to support and defend myself.
- As I learn to circulate, I let go of the craving for security and self-sufficiency.
- As I learn to circulate, I let go of the craving for idealized glory. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together to train and to heal. Hold us in the patterns and power of circulation as You guide us to our true glory. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to further our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

The spring KF training cycle always starts in March. If you are interested in joining the next KF training cycle, please register now on the website. New NHG graduates will be joining us, and you might pray for them as they make this transition. If you have invited someone to the NHG Study, please plan to support them by attending the upcoming KF Introductory Meeting. Thank you for all your efforts to live in karis with Karis Fellowships.

¹ www.youtube.com/watch?v=ihJAJA4ibEs.

² Mark 1:1213.

³ Phil. 3:14.

⁴ Heb. 3:13.

⁵ 2 Cor. 5:17.

⁶ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Golden_Rule.

⁷ Luke 6:28, 35.

⁸ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.